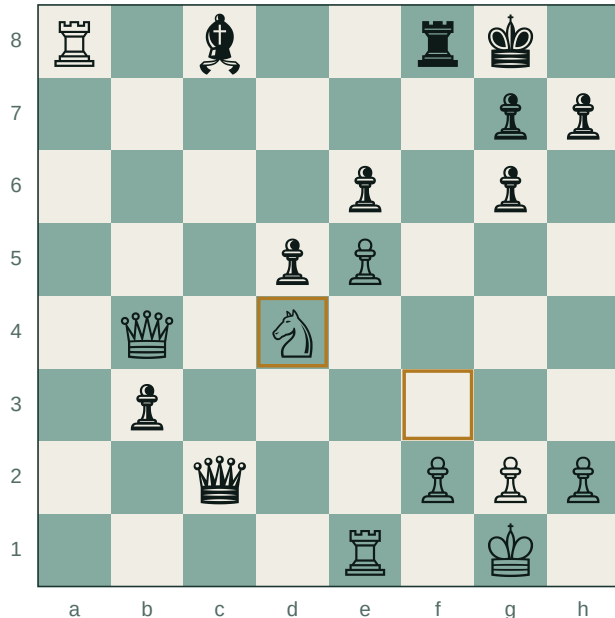


Back-rank mates: Black, move 21

Back-rank mates

Black to move



Previous move: 21.Nd4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

21...Qxf2+ 22. Kh1 Qf1+ 23. Rxf1 Rxf1#

21...Qxf2+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. From f2 it attacks king on g1, rook on e1 and knight on d4. Recorded reply: **22.Kh1**.

22...Qf1+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. From f1 it attacks king on h1 and rook on e1. Recorded reply: **23.Rxf1**.

23...Rxf1# Mate: rook on f1 gives check; White has no legal reply.

The line ends in checkmate against the king on h1. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

CHECKPOINT

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Rook on f1. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A flight square, an interposition, or a countercheck may refute an apparent mate. Check all three before sacrificing material.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A king trapped behind its own pawns may have no flight square when a rook or queen reaches its back rank. The entry square and its defenders are critical.

HOW TO LOOK

Inspect the king's pawn shelter, then find how a heavy piece can enter the last rank or remove its defender.

The defending king is on g1. Geometrically undefended: rook on a8 and queen on b4. Check for tactical protection.